

Grown-up's Playbook: The Market of Mixed-Up Magic

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which on the Isles means a few small jobs at once: narrator, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses.

Setting up

- You do not need a printed map for this one. Picture the Market Row, or lay out a few household objects to be the stalls and their goods.
- Each player chooses one magic: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice. Two different magics work best, because combining them is half the fun. (Voice is especially handy here, but every magic has a place.)
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the muddled goods (a loaf, a pair of boots, a kite, some fruit) from household bits and bricks, so the children can move them about. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Instead each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge in this story can be played with a single ordinary die, and richer dice sets simply make it feel grander.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to try the same idea again, or
- **Combine two magics** once per stop to pass the challenge with no roll at all (Voice and Light, say, or Change and Grow, working as one).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. So nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. The lesson underneath the whole game is that you get further together.

The surprise

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a surprise and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for surprises; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Surprise
1	A Messenger Butterfly flutters past and gives you one free hint.
2	A kind stallholder hands you a snack: take back one energy star.
3	A tidy little gust of wind: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Mist Cat appears and purrs. All is well; carry on.
5	You spot a helpful label nobody noticed: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A street musician strikes up a tune and everyone hums along for one happy turn.

How it ends

The market is not put right by catching anyone out. The muddle was made by Pip, a kind apprentice mage on their first day, whose Change spell slipped and who was too shy to admit it. The adventure is won when the children reassure Pip, show that mistakes are mended together, and give them the courage to set the last thing right. Let that land gently; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for how to play the ending, and for the solutions to the three stops.

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Muddled Stalls (Easy)

The challenge. Every object has jumped to the wrong stall. The players need a way to discover where each thing truly belongs.

Intended solutions. Any of the magics can help:

- **Voice** is the natural fit: ask each object where its home is, and it will happily tell you (the boots want the cobbler, the bread wants the baker, and so on).
- **Light** reveals a faint matching mark or colour that pairs each object to its stall.
- **Change** can mend a torn label so a stall can be read again.

Fallback. If a roll misses, the Mist Cat picks up one object in its mouth and carries it pointedly to the right stall, showing the children how, then they spend an energy star or combine two magics to finish the easy ones. Nobody is stuck for long.

Stop 2: The Memory of the Market (Normal)

The challenge. To return the rest, the players must remember the market as it was: which goods belonged at which stall.

Solution. This is a **memory** moment. The four pairings are:

- bread goes to the **baker**
- fruit goes to the **greengrocer**
- shoes go to the **cobbler**
- toys go to the **toymaker**

The Talking Flower hums the stalls in order to help. Let the children recall and place each pairing. Working it out with the flower's help still counts as a full success.

Fallback. If they freeze, have the Talking Flower sing the order slowly, one stall at a time, and let the players place one pairing per line. Getting there with a nudge tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Last Swap (Normal)

The challenge. Three stalls are tangled in a loop: the baker holds boots, the cobbler holds a kite, and the toymaker holds bread. The players must work out the passes that put everything right.

Solution. Each stall's own goods are: baker = bread, cobbler = shoes (boots), toymaker = toys (the kite). So it is a three-step ring:

- the **baker** passes the boots to the **cobbler**,
- the **cobbler** passes the kite to the **toymaker**,
- the **toymaker** passes the bread to the **baker**.

Then everyone holds their own. Lay out three objects and three stalls so the children can physically move them; the logic clicks once they see it as a ring.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the Mist Cat nudges the boots toward the cobbler to start the chain ("boots belong with shoes"), and the rest tends to follow. Solving it with one nudge is a full success.

Pip the New Mage (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. Behind a stall the players find **Pip**, a kind apprentice mage on their very first day, whose Change spell slipped and muddled the market, and who hid away out of worry and shyness.

Play it softly. Let the children decide how to reach out: a kind word, a reminder that everyone makes mistakes, an offer to stand beside Pip while they try again. There is no scolding and no trick. When the children reassure Pip, Pip finds the courage to set the last thing right with a careful Change, and the market cheers. End on that warmth. The children have won by being clever and kind, which is the only way anyone wins on the Isles.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 7.2, updated 2026-06-04, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.